

Building IM Toys

Let's learn how to develop a GTalk bot to access digg.com stories. The bot is a hosted program that can be added as a friend in an IM client, and the user interacts with it through the IM window.

"The world loves toys; they are fun to fiddle with."—Swami Someoneand.

Add *digg@bot.im* as your GTalk friend and type 'help' in its IM window. I assure you that it's not me at the other end typing menu items and

with it through the IM window.

First let us define what our bot will do:

1. It will give the user a menu of numbered categories. The user needs to type the number of the category he/she is interested in.
2. The bot will take the user input and fetch the top 10 popular stories for that category. The story abstracts, with the corresponding links, will be displayed in the IM window.

Before we start, we will need:

1. A mechanism to make GTalk find and connect to our PHP script.
2. APIs to connect to Digg and fetch the stories.

imified [www.imified.com] is a service that facilitates the creation of IM bots.

In short, it points a screen name on AIM, Yahoo, GTalk, and MSN chat services to our hosted script. You can register for a free account here.

Once you log in, go to *My Application*, then click on *Create Application*. Give your bot a GTalk Screen Name and a *General Identifier*. In the *Bot URL* field, enter the URL of your hosted PHP script. My script is hosted at <http://socialview.in/diggtoolkit/digg.php>. In the *Help Response* field, type in the response to be displayed when the user types 'help' in the IM window.

Download the PHP API from www.jaslabs.com/DownloadFiles/diggtoolkit.zip. Alternately, check <http://apidoc.digg.com/Toolkits> for APIs in a variety of languages. Go through the documentation to get familiar with the endpoints and the nomenclature. Thanks to its author, Justin Silverton, *diggclass.php* (present in *diggtoolkit.zip*) is well documented.

Our PHP script will have a simple logic:

1. Create an object of *diggclass*.

sending you Digg stories. A simple PHP script hosted on a Web server is accepting your messages and serving you content from digg.com while I attend classes, surf the Web and watch movies.

In this article, we'll learn how building this toy is both simple and fun.

An IM bot is a program that can be added as a friend in an Instant Messaging (IM) application, and the user interacts

